an over-reliance on singular leaders and a fragmented internal structure, have bred a certain hubris. The illusion of momentum has distracted Congress from its underlying issues. As an All India Congress Committee (AICC) official wryly stated: "Success often breeds complacency in the Congress, causing it to lose sight of the shifting political landscape."

RIDING ON ALLIANCES

Maharashtra and Jharkhand are headed for polls next month, so the party has no time to lose. After winning 13 of the 17 LS seats it contested in Maharashtra, the party had of late transitioned from being the "third ally" in the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) coalition to a more assertive role. It was even angling to contest the largest share of seats in the election, but the Haryana debacle will affect its position now. It's already happening. A day after the results, an editorial in *Saamna*, the mouthpiece of MVA ally Shiv Sena (UBT), was scathing in its comments, calling out the Congress for its inability to control its "disobedient leaders" and turning "a winning innings into a defeat".

Allies in the Opposition INDIA bloc have also dissected the Congress performance in J&K, particularly in the BJP's Jammu stronghold. The party won just one seat here, its worst performance ever, besides five others in the Valley. A closer examination of Congress's performance in the Lok Sabha election also reveals that much of its success was fuelled by alliances. In the 15 states and Union Territories where the Grand Old Party contested on its own, it won just 43 seats, which means that over half of its 99 seats came with the support of allies in the INDIA bloc. The Congress think-tanks will have to be much more accommodating of allies in Maharashtra and Jharkhand if they are to replicate previous successes.

The party seems to have learnt no lessons from the assembly poll disasters in Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh following the Karnataka victory in May 2023. Then too, the Congress had fallen into the trap of assuming that anti-incumbency and the BJP's perceived weaknesses would hand it easy victories.

In Karnataka, the Congress victory had been the product of meticulous planning. The party laid the groundwork two years in advance, enlisted the expertise of poll consultants and crafted a clear, coherent message. The 'five guarantees'—popular promises that resonated with voters—were announced well in time for it to gain traction with the electorate.

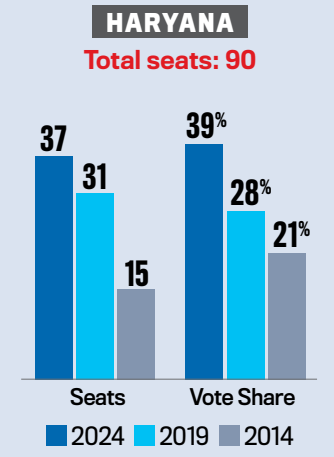
In sharp contrast, the campaign in Haryana was a tad unfocused. The party's 'seven guarantees' were announced with just weeks to go before the election. Rahul Gandhi, the party's star campaigner, spent just three days in the state. Worse, there was no real coordination between the Congress high command and local leaders—a chronic issue for the party, which continues to suffer from "fragmented leadership at key moments".

THE FISSURES WITHIN

The Haryana campaign also highlights the Congress's long-standing issue of factionalism. Ex-CM and prominent Jat leader Bhupinder Singh Hooda, 77, dominated the campaign, sidelining

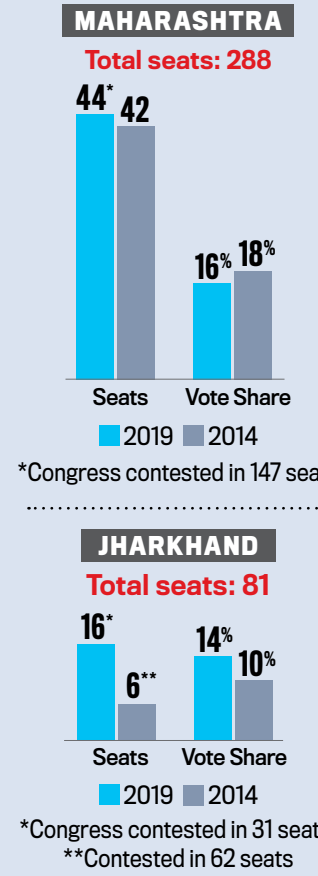
NOT A HAPPY OUTING

The Haryana assembly poll was a setback for the Congress, even the strike rate in J&K—19 per cent—was abysmal



THE NEXT TWO TESTS

Hopes rose after the Congress emerged the single-largest party in Maharashtra in LS poll. In Jharkhand, it's a minor ally



Vote share figures have been rounded off